

Strong handles were necessary for such a heavy pot to be removed from the fire.

Chariot burials

When an important person died, his chariot, charioteers, and horses were buried with him, as seen in this example found close to Anyang.

Xiaotun village, the remains have been uncovered of what was the ceremonial and administrative center of the late Shang state.

Burial customs

At Xibeigang, just north of Xiaotun, 11 huge graves have been found, which may belong to the 11 Shang monarchs who reigned at Anyang. When Shang kings died, they were buried in large cross-shaped graves. Their bodies were placed in wooden coffins surrounded by goods important to the deceased. The bodies of scores of slaughtered horses and human victims—possibly prisoners of war—were laid out on the ramps that led down to the burial chamber.

Bronze industry

The most prized archaeological finds from the Shang period are the bronze objects, made primarily for ceremonial purposes. The production of bronze was controlled by the king, and the quantity of bronze objects found indicates that it was a major industry, employing large numbers of skilled craftsmen. Early bronze technology in the West allowed an object to be cast from a single mold, but early Shang vessels were cast in several molds and the parts assembled later. Important finds of bronze vessels were made at the two capitals of Zhengzhou and Anyang. These vessels had ritual functions; some were intended for the preparation of sacrificial



meats, others for the heating of wine. Bronze was also used for musical instruments and for weapons, including swords and halberds, and hardware for chariots (see above).

Writing system

Along with a mastery of bronze, a complete writing system was created by the Shang, which had a huge effect on their organizational capabilities. Although some forms of early symbols appear on Neolithic pots and early Shang bronzes, the oldest inscriptions of complete sentences are found on oracle bones (see below). Over half of the known 2,500 symbols carved into the oracle bones can be read, and many closely resemble the Chinese characters of later times (see AFTER).

Bronze dagger

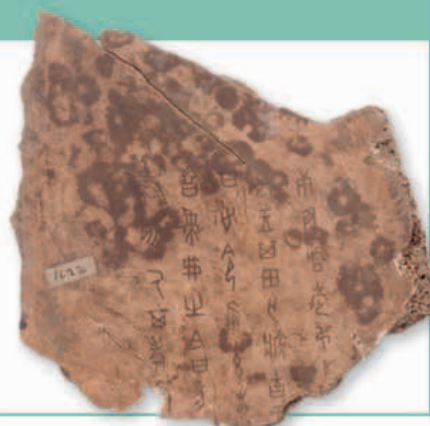
The highly ornamented handle of this dagger possibly depicts a stylized ram's head. Weapons such as this were probably used for ritual and sacrificial purposes.



HOW WE KNOW

ORACLE BONES

Sold in the 19th century as "dragon bones," an ingredient of Chinese medicine, "oracle bones" are actually the shoulder blades of cattle. Questions about the future would be scratched on the bones, to which a heated bronze tool was applied, and the resulting cracks were interpreted for an answer. Often, the predictions would be compared with the real event. They provide fascinating evidence not only of events in the Shang period, but also of early Chinese writing.



AFTER

Considered a tyrant, the last Shang ruler, Di Xin, was overthrown by the state of Zhou in the 11th century BCE. Many of the achievements of the Shang period, however, remain central to Chinese culture.

CHINESE CHARACTERS

The writing system created by the Shang developed over time into the Chinese characters in use today. The script was fixed in its present form during the Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE) 126–27 >>, and in 1716 the Kangxi Dictionary was published, containing over 47,000 characters. Studies in China have shown that full literacy requires a knowledge of 3,000–4,000 characters.



ANCIENT TEXTS

CALENDAR

The Shang created a lunar/solar calendar based on the zodiac, with ten "heavenly stems" and twelve "earthly branches." When combined together, the stems and branches formed cycles of sixty days or sixty years. The Shang model, although modified, remains the basis for the traditional Chinese calendar.

ANCESTOR WORSHIP

The Shang people worshipped many deities, most of whom were royal ancestors, and communicated with them through divination. This veneration of ancestors has remained an essential part of Chinese religious practice in modern times.



DIVINATION STICKS

Tripod shape is reminiscent of Longshan (Neolithic) pottery (see BEFORE)

Bronze ritual vessel

This highly patterned vessel was probably used by the Shang for the preparation of meat offerings.

